

The Tonkin Gulf Incident

In August 1964, the war escalated dramatically when North Vietnamese PT boats attacked two US destroyers in the Gulf of Tonkin. The first attack went unpunished, but claims of a second attack sparked the first US bombing of North Vietnam.

◀◀ BEFORE

Tensions in the Gulf of Tonkin mounted after the US authorized covert naval operations against North Vietnam.

GULF MISSIONS

In 1961, a reconnaissance and sabotage operation codenamed OPLAN 34-A was implemented by South Vietnamese commandos in high-speed patrol boats based at Da Nang. They were trained by **US Navy Seals** under CIA direction.

Meanwhile, the **DeSoto patrols**—secret missions carried out by US destroyers—began in 1962. They gathered intelligence on new Soviet radar and antiaircraft missile systems in the Tonkin Gulf.

The Joint Chiefs of Staff ordered Admiral Ulysses Grant Sharp Jr., US naval commander in the Pacific, to reactivate the DeSoto patrols in the Gulf of Tonkin in July 1964.

The USS *Maddox*, commanded by Captain John J. Herrick, was the first destroyer to be assigned to the task. One of its major objectives was to learn more about North Vietnam's coastal defenses. By August 1, Herrick's vessel was cruising in zigzags about 8 miles (13 km) from the North Vietnamese mainland and 4 miles (6 km) from Hon Me, one of the larger islands off the coast.

The first attack

The *Maddox* was not the only vessel active in the Gulf. Two days before its arrival, four South Vietnamese patrol boats sailed from Da Nang on a covert mission to raid the Soviet radar installations on two of the islands in the Gulf. Two of them shelled Hon Me on July 30 before withdrawing, while the others bombarded Hon Ngu. Herrick spotted the boats in the distance as they retired. He also picked up North Vietnamese radio traffic indicating that their naval forces were being put on high alert.

By mid-morning on August 2, the *Maddox* was nearing the mouth of the Red River Delta when Herrick observed three North Vietnamese patrol torpedo (PT) boats headed straight for the destroyer. Once they got to within 10,000 yards, Herrick ordered his gun crews to open fire. He also radioed the aircraft carrier USS *Ticonderoga* for assistance. Four jet fighters arrived overhead just as the PT boats launched their torpedoes. They all missed. Herrick's gunners badly damaged one of the PT boats, while the jets sank the second and damaged the third. The entire skirmish lasted exactly 37 minutes.

Johnson reacted immediately. The *Maddox* and the USS *Turner Joy*, another destroyer, were ordered to resume patrolling the Gulf and to attack any force that attacked them. The following evening, *Maddox* intercepted North Vietnamese radio messages, which gave Herrick the impression that another attack was imminent. He called for air support, but in the darkness neither the pilots nor the ships' crews could spot any enemy craft. Then *Maddox*'s sonar operators reported approaching torpedoes. Both destroyers opened fire in the direction of the sonar contacts, but were firing blind.